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# KF Introduction to NHG

## Chapter 4: *Neurotic Pride*<sup>1</sup>

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When we read about pride in the Bible, we can easily see that God is teaching us about neurotic, unhealthy pride. This pride exists only in our imagination; it is not based on real assets or evidence. As neurotics, we actually believe that our judgments, standards, expectations, and qualities are superior to those of others, including God's—and that's why neurotic pride is the kind of pride that God is forced to oppose. If God were to indiscriminately help us reach our potential while we were still committed to neurotic pride, we would not be able to recognize how this pride is killing us.

Although God opposes the proud, He gives grace to the humble. Who are the humble? They are those who choose to give up their neurotic pride and accept the reality of their strengths, weaknesses, and limitations. They are willing to learn how to stop wasting energy through controlling, competing, and comparing. Humble people receive grace from God. What is this grace? The Greek word for grace is *karis*. Karis Fellowships offers an expanded understanding of grace and trains us to live as allies of God. When people in the first century heard the good news of God's grace, they understood that God had given them the gift of Jesus, a gift that invited them into relationship with their Creator. With this understanding in mind, here is a paraphrase of First Peter 5:5-8.

<sup>5</sup>In the same way, you younger ones, place yourselves under the shelter of mature people. And all of you, bind yourselves up with humility in your dealings with each other for this very good reason: God stands against those who indulge in illusions of superiority, but to the humble He offers an invitation into a relationship with Him. <sup>6</sup>Be humble, therefore, under the strong hand of God so that He can raise you to real superiority at the appropriate time. <sup>7</sup>God is concerned about you, so go ahead and cast all of your cares onto Him. You no longer need to use your pride to resolve them. <sup>8</sup>Abstain from compulsive choices and behaviors. Refuse to live on autopilot, and stay awake because the devil, your opponent in the courtroom of your soul, pads around like a roaring lion seeking to swallow you up."

Take a deep breath.

In order to feel superior, we have to continually judge as good or bad both ourselves and others. Regardless of the evidence, we think that we know better, have the right answers, deserve more, have better intentions, are exempt from cause and effect, and have the best plan, not only for our own lives but for the lives of those around us. Our thoughts and ways are better than anyone else's, even God's.<sup>2</sup> Furthermore, we constantly, and often unconsciously, evaluate and judge our own thoughts, feelings, and choices, measuring them against our self-imposed standards. Our pride condemns us if we fail to fulfill those standards, and the fear of self-condemnation makes us chronically vigilant, rigid, anxious, and blind to possibilities. We become wildly defensive when our sense of security is challenged. Our self-esteem is

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<sup>1</sup> Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

<sup>2</sup> Isaiah 55:8-9.

on the line! Managing our proud standards requires a ton of energy. No wonder God warned Adam and Eve that tasting the fruit from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil would kill them!<sup>3</sup>

In our pride we compete with God, and like Adam and Eve, we firmly believe that we understand what is good and what is evil. We consider it our god-like duty to judge others and make them do what we think they should do. If others fail to meet our standards, or we fail to mold them to our standards, our pride is hurt and we suffer beyond the realities of the situation. On the other hand, we may abdicate responsibility and believe that it is evil to influence others or change ourselves. We may not even attempt to learn basic life skills. Instead, we pridefully presume that God will take care of everything for us, and we congratulate ourselves on our “faith”. But when through passivity and avoidance our lives become unmanageable, our pride is hurt, and we feel intense anxiety. Neurotic pride makes us vulnerable to an absurd degree.

Pride makes us untrustworthy in every relationship, even our relationship with God. Our compelling need to measure others against our standards, justify our judgments, and protect our pride prevents us from accepting or acknowledging others as they actually are and hinders the growth of any real relationship. You can see why Horney writes that pride is the enemy of love.

In the letters from Peter and James, we learn that pride and the devil go together. Pride feeds directly into the devil’s purposes, but there is an alternative to neurotic pride: you can learn to live in real humility, let go of the judgments of your pride system, and take the attitude of a learner with God as your Teacher. God would love to lift you up, if only you would let Him.<sup>4</sup>

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<sup>3</sup> Genesis 2:16-17.

<sup>4</sup> 1 Peter 5:6–10; James 4:6–10.

# KF Facilitator Guide

## Chapter 4: *Neurotic Pride*<sup>1</sup>

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0:00 Weekly/1:00 Weekend Intensive (WI). Go straight to the questions.

Lead Facilitator starts the recording by pressing \*9.

“Welcome everyone to chapter 4 of *Neurosis and Human Growth*. We will begin our study by reading Nancy’s introduction to the chapter.”

Support Facilitator reads the Introduction.

Lead Facilitator: “Thank you. Let’s go to Presenting. When you give us your name and location, you might also share something that you want or wish for. We can start with those living furthest east and move west. I will begin.”

“My name is \_\_\_\_\_. I am calling from \_\_\_\_\_ and what I want or wish for is \_\_\_\_\_.”

- Facilitators open the [NHG Spreadsheet](#) to record attendance and homework completion.
- Each facilitator makes a list of the names of students as they present.
- Lead facilitator prepares group divisions while students present.
- Lead facilitator assigns groups and says, “To leave the main group, press \*3 and then, when prompted, enter your group number. To return to the main group, press \*3\*.”
- Each facilitator asks, “Is there anyone who has not filled out their reading guide?”
- Each facilitator assigns the first 10 questions to two students, 5 questions each. Continue to answer the questions in sets of 10, assigning 5 questions per student in rotation.

Questions 3, 17, 37, and 48 are open to the whole group, and there are no correct answers.

0:20/1:10 WI

1. With all their strenuous efforts toward perfection, what do neurotics fail to attain? (86.1)  
**Self-confidence and self-respect; the neurotic has no inner security.**
2. What do children need to develop basic self-confidence? (86.2)  
**They need help from the outside: warmth, to feel welcome, care, protection, an atmosphere of confidence, encouragement in their activities, and constructive discipline.**
3. What factors in your upbringing may have been injurious to healthy growth? (87.2)  
**Open this question to the group.**  
Adults in the environment are too wrapped up in their own neurosis to be able to love their children, or even conceive of/recognize them as the particular, unique individuals that they are. Their attitudes toward their children are determined by their own neurotic needs.
4. What area is weakened by neurotic development? (87.3)  
**The core of our being.**  
We become alienated from ourselves and divided.

5. How do neurotics attempt to remedy the damage caused by self-alienation? (87.3)

**Through self-idealization. They attempt to lift themselves in their own minds above the crude reality of themselves and others.**

6. Instead of solid self-confidence, what does self-idealization give neurotics? (87.3)

**Neurotic pride.**

Pride wants some sort of glory or confirmation of value. Real self-confidence is content regardless of what others think or what happens to us. We can learn to assert our authority rather than assert our pride.

Dictionary definition of pride: self-esteem based on real or imagined merits.

For the neurotic, self-esteem is derived from imagined merits based on self-evaluation. Neurotics believe that these imagined merits entitle them to benefits from society and life and exemption from consequences.

7. What seems mysterious, arising from nowhere but most desirable for the neurotic? (87.4)

**Self-confidence.**

Definition of self-confidence: trust in one's own judgment or ability; reliance on one's own observation, opinions, or powers, without other aid.

8. What does the patient not know and is anxious not to realize? (88.1)

**The strict cause and effect relation between existing personal assets and the feeling of self-confidence.**

Neurotics are not interested in doing the work to develop real self-confidence. To achieve a veneer of self-confidence, they prefer to take the easier way of imagining personal merits that they believe deserve entitlements.

0:30/1:15 WI

9. What is healthy pride based upon? (88.3)

**Substantial attributes.**

Dr. Horney: Healthy pride may be a warranted high regard for special achievements, such as feeling proud of a deed of moral courage or of a job well done. Or it may be a more comprehensive feeling of our own value, a quiet feeling of dignity.

Christians are often taught to not take credit for their real achievements because it is "stealing glory from God." Yet we make choices and do things that require real work, courage, and trust which come from our own efforts to take up our own cross and follow Jesus.

10. Neurotic pride is extremely sensitive to what emotion? (88.4)

**Hurt.**

Pride makes hurt so much more painful. We can be hurt without anyone hurting us. Feeling hurt is often a flag indicating that we have invested pride in something.

People can feel hurt no matter what you actually say or do, simply because their pride has been hurt in some way. Apologizing to them may soothe their pride for a moment but will not heal their hurt.

Their hurt pride is really not your business. Your own hurt is your business. No one can hurt your soul if you have no neurotic pride to hurt.

11. How do neurotics relate to the group? (89.4–90.1)

**They are at bottom unrelated to the group and have no feeling of belonging but rather use the group for their personal prestige.**

Whether by attaching to the group (I am of this political party, race, church, identity group, or football team) or by judging it (I am not of that political party, church, or football team, etc.), all neurotics use the group to shore up their pride.

Judgment of others is a big part of supporting pride.

12. What is unhealthy about chasing prestige? (90.2)

**Chasing prestige makes people opportunistic and mars their integrity.**

Prestige or pride based on a group is not real. Our self-esteem is then jerked around by what the group does or doesn't do. We are unable to stand on our own assets, so we take advantage of the group's assets to support our pride. The pride is invested outside of ourselves.

Examples: Chasing a degree program; comparing self to others; classifying people; asserting knowledge, education, or experiences as a substitute for self-value.

13. What are neurotics NOT proud of? (90.3)

**The person they actually are.**

14. For what do neurotics have no appreciation at all? (90.3)

**A. They are not proud of their existing assets and may actually deny them. These assets carry no weight for them.**

**B. They have no appreciation for all that is "merely" striving and not accomplishment.**

Neurotics cannot praise themselves for hard work unless it is perfect, even when they are working to get to the roots of their troubles.

We need to appreciate ourselves for doing the work of this book study.

15. How do neurotics maintain their private fictitious world? (91.3)

**Through the incessant and largely unconscious work of intellect and imagination, they find ways to make things appear different from what they are.**

It is scary to watch others come up with very good reasons about why they behave as they do. We could turn that observation on ourselves and see how we are convinced by our most shallow justifications.

KF calls our private fiction "virtue stories." These are the stories we tell ourselves and others to justify what we think, feel, and do.

16. What is a regular occurrence in all neurosis? (92.1)

**The pride in intellect, or rather in the supremacy of the mind.**

We study our Bibles, go to seminars, and listen to speakers, which helps us feed our intellect, and we

then feel pride in what we know. Our good intentions to gather facts and ideas feed our pride whether we follow through with what we have learned or not.

In our neurosis we assume godlike attributes and think, “My ways are higher than your ways and my thoughts are higher than your thoughts” (Isaiah 55:9).

17. Which of these or other areas of pride do you recognize in yourself? (92.2)

**Open this question to the group.**

Looking perfect, acting perfect, being the perfect parent, and judging others for falling short.

Mastery: being right, grabbing control, winning, generating conflict in order to get a chance to win.

Self-effacing: acting compassionate and loving, giving in, being the victim, self-sacrifice.

Resigned: avoiding responsibility, getting others to do the work, refusing to change or grow.

0:40/1:10 WI

18. Why do the actual flaws of neurotics not count? (93.2)

**Because their pride is not in being moral but in knowing how they should be.**

If neurotics look at actual flaws, their whole pride system will collapse.

To keep our pride intact we focus on our imagined or petty flaws, admit to them, and joke about them, but we severely judge others for their flaws in a frantic effort to keep our pride intact. This is often why confessing our sins isn't healing us. We are confessing symptoms, not actual flaws.

Confessing our “sins” does not relieve our feelings or change our behavior, because we are confessing only the flaws that we allow ourselves to see and not those that are actually harming us.

Adam and Eve chose to instantly “know” good and evil without going through a natural development process. They were unwilling to make the effort to grow into the real knowledge of what is healthy and harmful and submit to the training that God offered to develop their internal moral guidance system. They had instantly decided what was “good” (the fruit) and chose evil (disobedience to God), and their awareness of good and evil did not help them deal with the realities of their consequences.

19. Are people proud of the same things? (93.3)

**No. There is nothing that may not be invested with pride.**

What is an asset to one person may be a disgraceful liability to another person.

20. Our neurotic pride will not tolerate the idea of being in the clutches of blind needs, so what must we do? (93.4–94.1)

**We must use our imagination to turn these needs into virtues, to transform them into assets of which we can be proud. Conversely, we tend to suppress, deny, and despise needs that obstruct this drive to actualize our idealized self.**

Examples of how we lie to keep our pride intact:

- I want you to be safe, but what I really need is to control you.
- I want you to be happy, but I really need you to need me.
- I want to work toward an essential goal, but what I really need is for everyone to do things my way and be my slave.

- I want to follow Jesus, but what I really need is to feel self-righteous.
- I want to be helpful, but what I really need is to impose my ideas and values.
- I want to make lots of money, but what I really need is to be free from the impositions of others.

We judge differently depending on who is involved. In Bertrand Russell's words, we might say: "I am firm" (a virtue); "You are obstinate" (a gentle reproach); "He is a pig-headed fool" (wrath, judgment, and indignation).<sup>2</sup>

21. As soon as we go off on a search for glory, what happens? (94.3)

**We stop being concerned about the truth of ourselves.**

This is the opposite of what God wants for us:

Psalm 15 – The righteous person speaks the truth in his heart.

Psalm 51 – God desires truth in our innermost being.

22. When are neurotics unable to regard a drive, an attitude, or a reaction as a problem to be tackled? (95.2)

**When they are unconsciously or consciously proud of it (the drive, attitude, or reaction).**

As Christians, we are often taught how to behave but are not taught how to handle the motivations and pride behind those behaviors. We unconsciously do the right things for the wrong reasons. We feed our pride rather than feeding our real self.

Examples:

- A man verbally attacks his wife. For a second he is ashamed of himself, but his pride takes over and tells him that she deserved his rebuke and that he was generous to help her.
- A woman cannot learn from or cooperate with others, but she tells herself that she would rather stick up for herself than be a "loser".
- A man gives in to others and lowers his boundaries, but he tells himself that he is unselfish and loving.

23. What are the two typical reactions to hurt pride? (95.3)

- Shame**
- Humiliation**

Whenever we feel shame or humiliation, our healing begins by examining how the situation that triggered the feelings hurt our pride system.

24. When do we feel ashamed? (95.3)

**When we do, think, or feel something that violates our pride.**

Examples:

- I experience shame when I fail to keep my house clean or fail to gain a promotion.
- One person feels shame for asserting themselves, another person for showing mercy or kindness.

25. When do we feel humiliated? (95.3)

**When others do something that hurts our pride or fail to do what our pride requires of them.**

Examples:

- I experience humiliation when my children mess up my house or when my colleague says stupid things in a meeting.
- I feel humiliated when others perform better than I do.

26. What two questions must we answer when any reaction of shame or humiliation seems out of place or out of proportion? (96.1)

- What in this particular situation has aroused this response?**
- What special underlying pride has been hurt by it?**

In our neurotic minds, we won't believe that we have pride issues. Admitting to pride issues is taboo, so we won't even look for the answers to these two questions.

27. What are we inclined to think determines our reactions? (97.2)

**The actual situation.**

A student said: "It's like I am playing a part in my own soap opera, and it's the script's fault that I am acting this way."

28. What determines our reactions more than the situation itself? (97.2)

**Our own neurotic needs.**

29. Why do aggressive expansive types often not react with feelings of shame? (97.3)

**They live so much in the imagination think that they are without blemish or they think everything they do is right.**

The aggressive expansive type protects himself from shame by living in his imagination and protecting himself with a layer of militant rightness. Everything that he does is right because he is the one doing it. Everything that he has or experiences is the best because he has it or is experiencing it. Whatever reaction he has that does not fit his idealized self-image is the fault of others, but whatever negative reactions others have toward him is their fault.

0:50/1:20 WI

30. Why do self-effacing types feel easily ashamed? (97.4)

**They focus on their failure to be the ultimate of perfection.**

Whenever others react to them negatively, they accept the reaction as evidence of their imperfection.

31. What inner condition greatly contributes to a diffuse irritability? (98.2)

**The fact that neurotics are vulnerable to an absurd degree, but their pride doesn't allow them to be vulnerable at all.**

They live in constant conflict with themselves, experiencing vulnerability but unable to acknowledge it. They are forced to be continually irritable in order to override the feelings of vulnerability. Their irritability keeps their mind focused on how "wrong" everyone and everything is and supports their own conviction that they are "right".

32. Other than shame and humiliation, direct reactions to hurt pride can be automatically transformed into what feelings? (98.3)

**Grief, disappointment, vague uneasiness, embarrassment, guilt.**

Other feelings that can be a reaction to hurt pride: depression, lethargy, loneliness, helplessness.



33. What are the prominent secondary reactions to hurt pride? (99.2)

- A. **Rage**
- B. **Fear**

These reactions are very automatic, and we believe that they are warranted by the stupidity or the wickedness of others.

34. When is the connection between hostility and hurt pride more easily discernible? (99.3)

**When the hostility has ingredients of derogation, contempt, or intent to humiliate.**

Derogation means to say or suggest that someone is not important or worthy of respect.

The law of retaliation: the person feels humiliated and returns in kind. Neurotics often retaliate out of humiliation, but they are unable to acknowledge that they feel humiliated.

35. What would save us from many painful or even heartbreaking troubles? (100.2)

**To think more often of the possibility that offensive behavior may stem from hurt pride.**

36. What do we fear when we cannot perform to the exacting standards of our shoulds? (101.1)

**We fear that our pride will be hurt.**

We then avoid doing anything that we fear will hurt our pride, and this confines us to repeating the same patterns and choices. We can refuse to take action or we can undermine our projects (or those of others) if those projects go against our neurotic pride system.

As Christians we may find this NHG study very difficult because our neurotic pride requires us to be godly and good. It hurts our pride to explore why our “good works are as filthy rags”. We are so proud of them!

37. For you, what activities stir up fear of rejection? (101.2)

**Open this question to the group.**

Activities can be in business, or personal life, relationships, spiritual disciplines, new skills, anything.

- Telling others what we really believe and think.
- Inability to control a situation, like being sick, asking for help.
- Beginning a project that others might judge, or in which you might fail, and then rejecting yourself. You might sabotage the project or yourself in order to have control over and avoid the possibility of rejection.
- Joining KF without knowing how it works could stir up the fear of rejection: “I might do it wrong and they won’t like me, or I won’t like myself!”

1:00/1:30 WI

38. Why do both rage and fear occur? (102.2)

**They occur because a hurt to our pride constitutes a terrifying danger.**

Fight or flight, primitive reactions to threat. We have no other basis for self-confidence than pride, and when that is threatened, we go into survival mode.

39. What two alternatives are open to the neurotic? (102.2)

- A. **Pride**

## B. Self-contempt

Mastery and resigned types will often not consciously feel a reaction of self-contempt but will become angry and irritable.

The self-effacing types feel a manufactured self-contempt as part of their pride system, but that is manageable for them. When they feel true self-contempt, it is paralyzing.

40. How do neurotics remedy the unbearable tension created by a pride system that they need but which at the same time makes them so vulnerable? (103.2)

**Neurotics remedy the unbearable tension through automatic endeavors to restore pride when it is hurt and to avoid injuries when it is endangered.**

Without training, if your pride is hurt, the only option you have right now is to defend it.

When we notice these automatic endeavors, our first step toward healing is to observe not to judge or condemn ourselves.

41. The most effective way to save face is interlinked with what? (103.3)

**The impulse to take revenge for what is felt as humiliation.**

Nothing short of absolute triumph will restore our pride. Anything less than a continual groveling in apologies, deference, or service from others feels insufficient because it does not make us feel better and restore our pride. Punishing our children or demanding apologies can be expressions of revenge and is extremely hard on children.

Ways of taking revenge:

- Vindictive daydreaming
- Gossip
- Making someone feel how much they have hurt me
- Repeatedly reminding someone of their mistakes
- Guilting, crying, depression, getting sick, staying sick, raging, moping, sulking, withholding

In the Bronze Age, when people took great offense for hurt pride, it would not have been an eye for an eye, as God mercifully commanded, but two eyes for one—or prolonged torture!

42. What do we believe will happen if we get back at the offender? (103.3)

**Our pride will be restored.**

Resisting revenge feelings and behaviors can create a lot of tension. That is one reason why we learn endurance and mindfulness in the beginning of our KF training. We have to be able to endure the tension of not pursuing vengeance.

43. What gives vindictiveness its incredible tenacity and accounts for its compulsive nature? (103.3)

**The capacity of vindictiveness to restore our pride.**

Cain killing Abel: "I can restore my pride by just getting rid of the person who humiliates me."

44. In the minds of certain types, the power to retaliate is equal to what? (103.4)

**Strength.**

For some retaliation is the only strength that they know.

45. What is the next most important method of restoring pride? (104.3)

**Losing interest in all situations or people who in some way hurt our pride.**

We can lose interest in this book study, KF training, or even our own healing work because our pride is hurt in some way.

Hurt pride often causes people to give up.

“I can’t produce something that will meet my standards, so rather than creating something imperfect, I will unconsciously self-sabotage or lose interest to protect my pride. I can only do things that I know will make me feel good about myself.”

46. When we lose interest in a relationship, what may actually have happened? (105.2)

**Something in the relationship has hurt our pride.**

- We feel ashamed if we cannot control others.
- We just don’t love them anymore.
- Our indifference to others is a reflection of our indifference to our real self.
- We have no interest in adjusting ourselves to others and unconsciously refuse to allow others to adjust to us.
- Liking turns into indifference for no good reason.
- We get bored with others.
- It is now clearer that pride is the enemy of love.

47. What is the most ruinous aspect of withdrawing from relationships? (105.3)

**We lose interest in our real self because we are not proud of it.**

When we withdraw from relationships that hurt our pride, we also withdraw our interest in working on ourselves.

Neurotic pride is all or nothing. Our desire to crush others is total. Hurt pride destabilizes the core of our being.

1:10/1:40 WI

48. Which of these or other methods of restoring pride have you seen in yourself or others? (104.3–106.3)

**Open this question to the group.**

- Winning at all costs; accusing and abusing others
- Distorting facts to make myself feel better about the situation
- Making others more wrong so that I can feel more right
- Excuses that feel like reasons – lack of time, lack of sleep, I was provoked, my intentions were good
- Combative retaliation: if they hurt me, I hurt them harder
- Believing that an apology sets everything right
- Losing interest in a person or activity
- Joking or humor
- Having grandiose ideas about myself, e.g. “I would be spectacular if only . . .”
- Preserving pride by refusing to take a risk
- Overcommitting, overspending, or over-giving to feel virtuous

49. What do all these devices for restoring pride have in common? (106.1)

**The tendency to refuse responsibility for self.**

We refuse to take responsibility for our own reality, emotions, choices, contributions, thoughts, efforts, and experiences.

Taking responsibility for yourself is another way of taking up your power.

50. How does the neurotic avoid future hurt to pride? (106.4)

**By building an elaborate system of avoidances in the hope of circumventing future hurts.**

- Avoiding activities, people, groups
- Blocking any realistic striving and effort
- Avoiding acknowledgement and exploration of true wishes
- Restricting life to a comfortable mediocrity
- Entrenchment in a fantasy world
- Blaming neurosis for my behavior
- Although God our Creator has saved us, we believe that we are totally depraved sinners and cannot therefore expect anything positive from ourselves
- Missing or avoiding opportunities that might threaten our pride

51. What is the enemy of love? (108.1)

**Pride.**

1:15 All weekly subgroups return to main group for discussion and closing by pressing \*3\*.

1:45 WI subgroups return to main group by pressing \*3\*.

Lead Facilitator: Dismiss the group and stop the recording (\*9 then 1).

All facilitators, please stay after the meeting to confirm student attendance and homework completion on the [NHG Attendance Spreadsheet](#).

Lead Facilitator: "Are there any comments or questions?"

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<sup>1</sup> This reading guide refers to the 1991 edition of *Neurosis and Human Growth: The Struggle Toward Self-Realization* by Karen Horney, published by W.W. Norton and Company Inc. New York.

<sup>2</sup> [www.lifesayingsquotes.com/quote/firm-you-obstinate-pig-headed-73/](http://www.lifesayingsquotes.com/quote/firm-you-obstinate-pig-headed-73/).